Under the successive kings of Chandragupta Maurya's dynasty, the entire subcontinent was eventually absorbed within the Maurya Empire. Most of the border expansion was due to Chandragupta's grandson, Emperor Ashoka, who is simultaneously remembered as one of India's greatest rulers and one of its most violent. Bindusara and Ashoka were responsible for solidifying the economy of their empire, though through vastly different means. While Bindusara was a largely diplomatic ruler, using pacts and friendly foreign relations to keep borders strong and trade blossoming; Ashoka did so through fear and pillage.

Emperor Ashoka is considered by many to be the greatest ruler in Indian history, not because of his territorial exploits but because he became a different emperor after grief and shame struck him in the heart. It is believed he died of natural causes in 232 BCE.